

BEWITCHED BY HOCKEY
The Hockey Chowk in Rourkela; right, the sculpture of a hockey player near the Rourkela airport; below, the Indian team practising at the inauguration of the Birsa Munda Stadium

Rourkela is all dressed up for a carnival of sport. Colourful Pipili appliqué lampshades hang from trees; bright murals of hockey, yoga poses, Odissi dancers, birds, flowers and more adorn walls; the Hockey Chowk, studded with sculptures, lights up at night, as does the hockey-themed Champions Garden. Then, there is five-time Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik smiling down from innumerable hoardings, along with Olly the green turtle, who is the official mascot of the FIH Odisha Hockey Men's World Cup 2023. Odisha is the first state to host back-to-back editions of the world's premier hockey tournament. This time around, in addition to Bhubaneswar, it is bringing the best of the world to the *garh* (den) of hockey—the mineral-rich district of Sundargarh—which has seen around 60 players, male and female, play for the national teams, most popular among them former captain Dilip Tirkey, currently president, Hockey India. Indeed, the fact that Odisha are now equal sharers with Punjab of the title 'the nursery of Indian hockey' is well acknowledged. Its hosting a second World Cup in five years and the passionate involvement of everyone on the ground shows the depths to which the game's popularity has spread here.

India's goalkeeper P.R. Sreejesh, playing in his fourth World Cup, could barely recognise the Steel City, as Rourkela is popularly known, when he arrived with his teammates towards the end of December 2022. "When I camped here in 2006, there was hardly anything," he says. "Now...the roads look like Europe. The infrastructure they have built is marvellous and equal to an Olympics venue." Sreejesh is lavishing praise on the Birsa Munda Hockey Stadium, a 21,000-seater sporting arena, one of the world's largest, which was finished in 15 months. Built on the campus of the Biju Patnaik University of Technology, it also houses a 225-bed accommodation, in addition to a gym, a swimming pool, a sauna, another astro turf practice pitch and a recovery centre.



Under Patnaik's leadership, Odisha has become synonymous with hockey. The state became the official sponsor of the national men's and women's team in 2018 with a five-year, Rs 100 crore sponsorship deal. It recently extended the association for an undisclosed fee until 2033. At the stadium's launch on January 5, Patnaik described the venue as "Odisha's gift to the nation" and "a